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KEMMOTTEVILLE, VA.



High-rise apartments for American tourists (background) contrasts with the squalor of shanty huts in San Juan, Puerto Rico. The Puerto Rican people have overwhelmingly rejected President Ford's lame-duck proposal to make the Caribbean island the 51st state.

(New York, N.Y.) - Widespread outrage and indignation have erupted throughout the island of Puerto Rico and in Puerto Rican communities in the U.S. in opposition to President Gerald Ford's lame-duck proposal to make the small Caribbean island America's 51st state.

Here in New York, representatives of the Puerto Rican Socialist Party (PSP) condemned President Ford's initiative, made without the consultation of any leading Puerto Rican official, as "a violation of the principle of self-determination," and strongly reasserted the popular view that the question of the sovereignty of the Puerto Rican nation must precede any discussion of status.

In making his sudden New Year's Eve announcement, President Ford totally reverses and negated this process. Under his proposal the U.S. Congress would first draft and pass statehood legislation; the Puerto Rican government would then draft an acceptable state constitution; and finally, a plebiscite would be conducted to determine if the Puerto Rican people wanted statehood.

In a statement to THE BLACK PANTHER, PSP representative Jose Laluz said:

"The announcement by President Ford constitutes a violation of the principle of self-determination of peoples to which this country subscribes in its Declaration of Independence and in its Constitution.

"It also reveals the colonial relationship between the U.S. and Puerto Rico when it proposes to resolve the status question
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